

AFP

**HEAVING STREETS**
**Jubilant Bangladeshis at the office of ousted PM Sheikh Hasina in Dhaka, Aug. 5**

and economic growth for Bangladesh hasn't trickled down; absolutism and corruption have. A firestorm of anti-state violence erupted. Rioters destroyed public property and killed ruling party workers, even police. Curfew and shoot-at-sight orders were imposed at midnight on July 19. The army came to the streets.

A week later, I was at dinner at the Dhaka residence of a major businessman. A top newspaper editor had joined us. The army being deployed was interpreted to me as an indication that India had Hasina's back. There was talk of "enduring regimes"; the chances of Sheikh Hasina's sister Rehana stepping in, supported by her technocrat son and a daughter who is an MP in the United Kingdom.

All moot, as it turned out. The same as when Hasina's government pressured a court to rescind the quota and, despite all the killing it had presided over, expected the students, now fired-up citizens, and even a greatly energised opposition, to stand down. It had the opposite effect.

In all this, the perception of India shielding the leaders of a corrupt, cronyism-led, hubris-laden, absolutist government has persisted. The arrival on August 5 of a Hasina-on-the-run at Hindon air force base reinforced such beliefs. After she fled, rioters attacked and set fire to the former Indian High Commission premises on Road No. 2 in Dhanmondi, which has since 2010 been repurposed as the Indira Gandhi Cultural Centre.

India has appalling optics in Bangladesh, especially so since 2022 when it amped up its G2G play. But, away from this ivory tower government-to-government bonhomie, India suffers from a significant P2P, or people-to-people trust deficit in Bangladesh. India's establishment ideologues and foreign policy wonks might choose to not see it, blinded as they are—were—by easy access to prime ministerial orbits.

**Hasina's undeniably impressive infrastructure development and economic growth for Bangladesh haven't trickled down; absolutism and corruption have**

Distrust exists despite a strong bilateral relationship that has evolved into one of impressive functionality, particularly in trade, connectivity and tourism. To mend bilateral dysfunctionality, India needs to recognise that Bangladeshis have moved on since 1971. This realisation should lead to greater respect, a lessening of presumption, better communication and optics, concessions in trade and the prickly issue of sharing river waters.

Meanwhile, protesting students and student leaders have displayed impressive smarts. During conversations with the president and service chiefs, they insisted that they are neither interested in the declaration of an Emergency nor in military rule; both are spectres of been-there-lived-through-that horrors. Students selected economist Muhammad Yunus to head the interim government. Bangladesh's president would merely swear him in. Students also remain watchful about the resurgence of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP), adept at mastanocracy during their time in power that ended over 15 years ago; and, of the rise of extreme Islamists which, in tandem with a flexing BNP, could diminish democracy.

In a little over a month, students have graduated from deconstruction to reconstruction. Administrators, politicians, policymakers—and educators—are now being schooled by them. ■

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